and determined effort to educate their children and for this they have not spared any sacrifice or effort.

'Don't you feel as though this is a letter from an abandoned brother?' Shekhawat asked me. 'We launched some covert action immediately after the coup in 1987, but hardline Fijian groups accused us of meddling in Fiji's internal affairs and any covert action from our side at that moment could have gone against the interest of Indian community.'

Fiji's ethnic Indians weren't abandoned, however. The evacuation of India's spies was merely a tactical retreat. 'We did not protest when our officers were declared persona non grata in Fiji. We returned to India to plan something bigger, something spectacular,' said Shekhawat. 'In a meeting sometime in September, a decision was taken that the future spy operation in Fiji would not involve the external affairs ministry. We were planning to fight on our own, but reports from our informers in Australia were very depressing. A report sent to us with a newspaper clip of the Sunday Telegraph revealed that Indian women were gang-raped by the Rabuka led Fijian soldiers.'

The news report added that seventeen children from the sugar town of Ba had been beaten and made to eat cow dung for violating government edicts that banned picnics and swimming on Sundays and that villagers were forced to bathe in raw sewage. As the mood of Colonel Rabuka's regime darkened, there was mounting evidence of human rights abuses against the island's Indians.

While the spies in India planned their operation, Rabuka's opponents, the members of the deposed government and political parties, were re-arrested. Shekhawat said Timoci